

digital transformation of our steel manufacturing operations,” says Acharya. The plan is to deploy game-changing advanced technologies such as AI/ML, robotics, standard and advanced analytics, edge computing and cloud deployments, plus the introduction of robotic process automation (RPA)/bot-based interventions and intelligent digital video analytics. “These technological interventions will enable JSW Steel to create a network of digitally connected smart steel factories in India.” The company’s transition to digitally connected smart steel manufacturing includes three critical parts—creating a smart iron zone, creating a smart steel zone and developing a smart milling zone.

The apprehension that AI will displace jobs does not find too many takers. ABB’s Sharma predicts there will be a different nature of jobs created during the period. “From a business point of view, companies must be patient since expectations are high and [the] approach should be one of patient capital,” he explains. Sharma equates it to a bamboo tree, which hardly grows for five years and then sharply takes off. JSW Steel’s Acharya says AI will alter the job dynamics, especially for those who are underprepared. “The advent of digital transformation will require specific skill sets and manpower, and that can come from a judicious mix of lateral hires with digital skills and upskilling the current employee base,” he points out. At a group level, the entity has created a multi-disciplinary task force of high-potential employees comprising more than 50 data scientists—to be expanded to 100—to steer digital transformation across its businesses.

On the issue of reskilling, an interesting view comes from Tata Steel’s Banerjee. “In the past, a car had a rear-view mirror and now there is a dashboard. To put that together, you need a very able and skilled bunch of people,” he says. To elaborate the point, Banerjee thinks the co-pilot will always be of great assistance: “But there needs to be a pilot and that is the human. In this transition, the human can never be outrun by technology.” In that sense, the disruption will come in the form of reskilling. His company took the route of investing in cloud and then data. “Every technology is critical and must be put to good use. But it must still deliver on an RoI basis and that is how it will be judged.” In that sense, companies will look at AI in the same manner. How they manage to do it in a world where agility is the buzzword is what will separate the men from the boys. The story has barely started. **BT**

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The Machine Bankers

THE RISE OF MACHINE BANKERS IS ALL SET TO TRANSFORM THE BANKING SECTOR AND HAS SIGNIFICANT IMPLICATIONS FOR CUSTOMERS AND SHAREHOLDERS ALIKE

BY **ANAND ADHIKARI**

YOU CALL AN HDFC BANK call centre. Lady AI responds: Namaskar, welcome to HDFC Bank.

You: *Mera credit card balance batayein.* (What is my credit card balance?)

Lady AI: You want to know your credit card outstanding balance, is that correct?

You: *Haan.* (Yes.)

After confirming your identity, Lady AI announces your card balance to you. If the call drops midway and

